CLAUDE EXPORT

Designing a fictional underground city

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I want to design a fictional city built around an abandoned underground transit network that people have started using again.
Let's build it together over several turns. Start by asking me 6-8 focused questions about the city, the tunnels, who controls access, what dangers exist below, how ordinary people use the network, and what kind of story tone I want.
After I answer, help me turn it into a practical worldbuilding plan with districts, transit rules, social tensions, failure points, and a few story hooks.

This is a great worldbuilding premise. Let me ask the right questions to shape it properly.

Take your time with these. Your answers will shape everything, from the district names to the power structure to the story hooks.

Q: What's the general feel of the city above ground?
A: Retro-futurist, alternate history vibes

Q: How did the transit network get abandoned in the first place?
A: A disaster (flood, war, plague, accident)

Q: Who controls access to the tunnels now? (Select all that apply)
A: A grassroots community that self-governs

Q: What's the primary reason ordinary people use the underground network? (Select all that apply)
A: Privacy — no surveillance cameras down there

Q: What's the biggest danger below ground? (Select all that apply)
A: Something stranger — creatures, contamination, unexplained phenomena

Q: What's the tone and genre you want for stories set here?
A: Adventure with heart — ensemble cast, camaraderie, hope

Excellent foundation. Before I build the full worldbuilding plan, I have a few targeted follow-up questions to nail down the specifics.

These three answers will lock in the disaster's legacy, the world's aesthetic DNA, and the nature of the underground mystery. All three feed directly into the worldbuilding plan.

Q: What was the disaster that closed the tunnels, and roughly when did it happen relative to the story's present day?
A: An industrial accident (gas, fire, collapse) that the city covered up

Q: What's the retro-futurist flavor of the world above? This shapes architecture, technology, and politics.
A: 1960s space-race idealism — sleek modernism, orbital ambitions, social upheaval

Q: What kind of 'strange' exists in the tunnels? This is the world's most delicious mystery.
A: Bioluminescent organisms and mutated wildlife — nature reclaimed the dark

Now I have everything I need. Let me build this out properly.

Here is the full worldbuilding plan for your city.

Here is the full worldbuilding plan. Let me present it as text since the visual widget timed out.

Veldrun — City Built on a Buried Accident

The City Above

Veldrun is a coastal megalopolis frozen in the aesthetic of orbital optimism. Brushed-aluminum spires, glass curtain walls, porcelain-tiled transit corridors with hand-lettered station signage. Municipal fusion reactors. Giant curved civic screens above the plazas. On the surface, Veldrun is a city that believes in itself. Below, it is hiding something.

The Disaster: The Pocket Fire, 27 Years Ago

During expansion of the Meridian Line, tunnel boring punched through a sealed geological cavity containing an unknown compound. The resulting gas ignition killed 41 workers across three stations and buckled nearly two kilometers of track. The city sealed the entire network within 72 hours and classified the geological surveys. The official story blamed a contractor's faulty equipment. Families of the dead received settlements with non-disclosure clauses. The whole network was shuttered "pending structural review" — a review that never published results. The compound's origin and composition remain classified. What it did to the tunnel environment in the intervening decades, the city has not officially investigated.

The Six Districts Above Ground

The Meridian (civic core) — Government towers, broadcast studios, the Municipal Transit Authority. Home of the official silence.

The Colonnades (commerce) — Finance, retail arcades, elevated walkways. Surface surveillance is densest here. People use the tunnels specifically to escape it.

Ironbell (working class) — Foundries, dockworkers, the old union halls. The Pocket Fire's dead were mostly Ironbell families. Tunnel use here is generational.

Tessmer Heights (academic) — University, research institutes, the natural sciences museum. A few biologists have begun quietly studying samples from below.

The Margin (contested) — Migrant quarter, informal housing, street markets. The tunnels here are busiest. Surveillance cameras above, none below.

Saltgate (industrial) — Port facilities, cold storage, processing plants. Several tunnel access points are hidden inside warehouses here.

Who Governs Underground: The Stewards

No single faction controls the tunnels. What exists is the Stewards: a loose, self-appointed council of roughly forty people who maintain the network's informal rules. Many are descendants of the original transit workers who lost family in the Pocket Fire. Others are Margin residents who needed the tunnels to survive the city's surveillance economy.

The Stewards carry no weapons. Their authority is social: reputation, history, and the willingness to do unglamorous maintenance work.

Three tiers within the Stewards: the **Keeper-Generals** (seven senior members who arbitrate disputes and meet monthly in the Ironbell junction hub), the **Line Wardens** (one or two per corridor, who know their stretch intimately), and the **Lamplighters** (volunteers who harvest and cultivate bioluminescent growth to light safe passages, and who have become expert naturalists by accident).

Transit Rules

- Entry points are unmarked and word-of-mouth only. Newcomers must be vouched for by a current tunnel-user. The Stewards call this "the introduction."
- Artificial light is permitted but discouraged in deep tunnels. The bioluminescent growth responds to bright light with a retreat period that takes hours to reverse.
- The old rail cars are non-functional. Converted handcarts travel fixed routes on a loose schedule maintained by Line Wardens. Fares are barter or labor.

- No written maps. A lost document could expose hundreds of people to city enforcement.
- The Deep Zones, furthest from the incident site, are open. The Scar Zones near the original collapse are restricted to Steward-approved teams only.
- The core compact: you do not bring violence underground. Disputes above stay above. The tunnels are neutral ground.

What Lives Below

In 27 years of sealed darkness, the tunnels became something else. The geological compound altered soil chemistry, moisture, and growth conditions for organisms that had no business thriving in a transit tunnel.

The Bloom (documented) — Fungal networks covering whole corridor walls in slow-pulsing blue-green light. The Lamplighters have learned to read pulse patterns as rough indicators of air quality and structural stress.

Tunnel mice (documented) — Several generations removed from surface rodents. Now eyeless, translucent skin, bioluminescent gut bacteria. Harmless. Children love them. Stewards consider them good omens.

The Architects (partially understood) — Large, slow-moving creatures, possibly crustacean in origin, observed reinforcing tunnel walls with secreted mineral compounds. Nobody knows if this is intentional. Nobody has been harmed by one.

The Listening (contested) — A low subsonic hum in the Scar Zones that seems to respond to human presence. Some say it's the geology. Some say it's the Bloom. Some refuse to say.

The deep water (unknown) — The flooded sub-basement of the Meridian Line's central hub. Completely dark, untraveled. Things move in it. Steward standing orders: do not go in. Do not shine light in. Do not discuss what you have seen.

Compound persistence (rumored) — Some long-term tunnel-users show unusual changes: improved night vision, sensitivity to subsonic frequencies, faint bioluminescent skin responses under UV. The Stewards track this quietly and say nothing to the surface.

Social Tensions

Openness vs security. The tunnels work because entry is controlled. But every person refused a vouching could be someone who genuinely needs the network: a migrant dodging deportation, a whistleblower, a sick child needing to reach a clinic without a city ID scan.

The Bloom vs human traffic. Heavy tunnel use is slowly degrading the ecology. The Lamplighters know it. Most tunnel-users do not. If the Bloom retreats, the tunnels go dark and dangerous.

Steward authority vs popular will. The Stewards are unelected. A charismatic rival who promises to open the tunnels to everyone could fracture the council without firing a shot.

The city above vs the city below. The Municipal Transit Authority has never officially acknowledged that people are using the tunnels. The day they do, everything changes.

Scientific curiosity vs protective silence. The Tessmer Heights biologists want samples and access. The Stewards know that real scientific attention is a short road to city attention. But the compound's effects on long-term users may require medical knowledge the Stewards don't have.

Five Story Hooks

1. A Steward's kid goes into the Scar Zone. Seventeen years old, born after the Pocket Fire, tired of being told what she can't see. She comes back changed: not harmed exactly, but different. Her parent must decide whether to report it to the council or protect her. The answer will define what kind of leader they are.

2. The city proposes a new transit line. The Municipal Transit Authority announces plans to modernize the old network. Officially about congestion. What the announcement omits: the city has been monitoring tunnel activity for three years. The Stewards have 90 days before construction crews arrive.

3. Someone is selling tunnel access. A broker in the Margin is charging desperate people for guaranteed entry without vouching. The Stewards don't know who it is. The broker's clients keep arriving in sections they shouldn't know about. Someone on the inside is talking.

4. The Architects stop building. For the first time in recorded Steward history, the large crustacean creatures have gone still and retreated to the deep tunnels. A section they had been reinforcing for months begins showing stress fractures within a week.

5. A Pocket Fire survivor resurfaces. One of the 41 dead was listed as killed but the body was never recovered. After 27 years, a person matching his description is seen in the deep tunnels by a Lamplighter: bioluminescent, calm, and apparently at home in total darkness. He did not want to be found.

Ready to go deeper on any of this. We could develop the Steward council as characters, flesh out the ecology further, or start building one of these story hooks into a full episode or chapter structure.

lets go deeper on each of the six districts

Let's build them out properly. A few quick questions first so each district has real texture.

These three answers will give each district a distinct look, a specific relationship to the surveillance economy, and a clear sense of where the story's emotional gravity lives.

Q: What era does Veldrun's retro-futurism peak at aesthetically? This shapes how each district looks and what its architecture signals about its status.
A: Mid 60s — space race fever, bold geometry, everything reaching skyward

Q: How does the city's surveillance system work above ground? This shapes what the tunnels mean to each district differently.
A: Camera networks with facial recognition — no checkpoints, but you're always watched

Q: Which district do you want to be the emotional heart of the story — the one whose people and stakes feel most central?
A: Ironbell — the working class district that lost the most in the Pocket Fire

Perfect. Ironbell as the heart gives the whole world a moral anchor. Here are all six districts, fully built out.

The Six Districts of Veldrun

Aesthetic Foundation

Veldrun's peak is 1965 in spirit: everything angular and reaching, public buildings designed to make citizens feel small in the best possible way, like standing at the base of a rocket. Concrete hyperbolic paraboloids over civic plazas. Cantilevered observation decks. Station facades in glazed brick the color of a clear morning sky. The city's visual language says: *we are going somewhere*. The camera networks say: *and we are watching you go there*.

The facial recognition grid covers every public surface. There are no checkpoints, no visible enforcement apparatus. Just lenses, small and flush-mounted, on every transit pillar, every plaza lamp standard, every shop awning bracket. Residents know they are there. Most have simply adjusted their lives around the knowledge. Some have not been able to.

Ironbell

The Emotional Heart

Ironbell sits at the western edge of Veldrun where the city meets the industrial waterfront, a district that was never supposed to be beautiful and made its peace with that long ago. The architecture here predates the space-race aesthetic by a decade: brick foundry buildings with arched windows, union halls with carved stone lintels, terraced workers' housing on steep streets that run straight down to the water. Where the civic modernization reached Ironbell it arrived selectively, dropping a gleaming concrete community center into the middle of a block of century-old rowhouses like a statement nobody asked for.

Ironbell lost nineteen of the forty-one workers who died in the Pocket Fire. The names are on a plaque outside the union hall. The plaque was paid for by the union, not the city. The city sent a representative to the unveiling, said the appropriate words, and has not officially mentioned the Pocket Fire since.

The district has a particular relationship with silence. People here know what happened. They know the settlements came with non-disclosure clauses. They know the review never published. The knowledge is carried in families, passed down not as anger exactly but as a specific kind of wariness about official things. About announcements. About the word *pending*.

The facial recognition cameras in Ironbell were installed last among all the districts, five years after the rest of the city, which residents took as a small insult layered on top of all the larger ones. They are there now. The tunnel access points in Ironbell are the oldest and most carefully maintained in the network. Several are inside the union hall basement itself. The Stewards' Keeper-General council meets within walking distance of where the workers used to clock in.

What Ironbell wants is not revenge. It wants acknowledgment. It wants someone in the Meridian to say, out loud, that nineteen people died and the city knew why and told no one. It has been waiting twenty-seven years. It has gotten very good at waiting.

Signature locations: The Plaque Wall outside Ironbell Union Local 7. The Tidal Steps, a wide public staircase descending to the waterfront where families gather on the anniversary of the Fire. The Anchor and Lantern, a pub that has been in the same family for four generations and where the informal tunnel vouching often happens over drinks. The Meridian Line memorial mosaic in the old Ironbell Station entry hall, sealed behind glass and accessible only from a locked maintenance corridor the Stewards have a copy of the key to.

What the cameras mean here: Ironbell residents have largely stopped doing anything in public they wouldn't want documented. This is a slow-motion grief of its own. The tunnels are where people say true things to each other.

The Meridian

The Civic Core

The Meridian is Veldrun at its most deliberate. Every building here was designed to project authority through geometry: the Municipal Tower is a perfect tapered octagon clad in champagne-colored aluminum, visible from every district in the city. The Transit Authority headquarters is a long horizontal slab on pilotis, the kind of building that communicates rationality by refusing to touch the ground. The civic plaza at its center contains a fountain shaped like a stylized orbital ring, which runs on a timer and is off more often than it is on.

This is where the cover-up lives, not as a conspiracy exactly but as a bureaucratic habit. The original decision to seal the network and classify the surveys was made by people who are now retired or dead. What remains is institutional inertia: departments that have been not-discussing the Pocket Fire for so long that not discussing it has become the default, unremarkable, automatic. Junior officials inherit the silence without ever being told explicitly to maintain it. They simply notice that nobody asks, and they do not volunteer.

The camera grid in the Meridian is the densest in the city. This is officially for security. Unofficially, officials have long since learned to hold sensitive conversations in the one category of space the cameras cannot see: the tunnels below. The irony that city employees use the Steward network for privacy has not been lost on the Keeper-Generals, who know more about the Transit Authority's internal politics than any journalist in the city.

Signature locations: The Municipal Tower observation deck, open to the public on scheduled days, from which you can see Ironbell's church steeples and the waterfront cranes on clear mornings. The Transit Authority Archive, sub-basement three, which requires a special clearance card that exactly four people currently hold. The Civic Memory Hall, a museum of Veldrun's history that has a beautifully produced exhibit on the Meridian Line's construction and stops abruptly at 1962, six years before it opened and nine years before the Fire.

What the cameras mean here: Officials have learned to perform for them. Public movements are deliberate and legible. The cameras have created a culture of managed visibility, where what you do in the frame is a kind of speech act. Going off-camera is a power move available only to those who know the routes.

The Colonnades

Commerce and Controlled Movement

The Colonnades is Veldrun's commercial district in the most architectural sense: a district literally built around movement. Elevated walkways connect building to building at the second-floor level, forming a pedestrian network above the street that was intended to separate shoppers from delivery traffic and ended up separating wealthy residents from everyone else. The surface level is service: loading docks, kitchen entrances, the unglamorous infrastructure of the economy. The colonnade level is display: glass-fronted retailers, café terraces, the offices of financial firms with names that sound like law firms.

The camera density here is the second highest in the city, marginally behind the Meridian. The Colonnades' business association lobbied for it, arguing that visible security infrastructure supports retail confidence. What they got was invisible security infrastructure, which they accepted. Shopkeepers know that a person who lingers too long near an entrance gets flagged. Delivery workers know their route times are logged. The district runs efficiently and the efficiency has a texture of pressure underneath it.

The tunnel access points in the Colonnades are used primarily by two groups: workers who cannot afford the surface rail's fare structure even without a checkpoint, and a smaller group of financial professionals who use the privacy to conduct conversations they do not want attributed to them. The Stewards are matter-of-fact about this. Everyone has reasons. You do not ask for reasons.

Signature locations: The Exchange Hall, a mid-century trading floor with a spectacular coffered ceiling and a digital ticker that replaced the original mechanical one in a modernization effort that everyone found slightly sad. The Covered Market on the service level, technically below the colonnade network and technically not maintained by the business association, where the prices are lower and the cameras have worse angles. The Crestline Hotel, seventeen stories of curtain-wall glass where at least two city council members maintain permanent suites.

What the cameras mean here: The Colonnades camera network has created an informal geography of safe and unsafe movement. Workers know the angles. Certain corners have become shorthand for conversations you can have.

Tessmer Heights

The Academic District

Tessmer Heights climbs the steep ridge on Veldrun's northern side, a district of stone staircases, overgrown campus quads, and lecture buildings whose mid-century renovations sit awkwardly atop Victorian foundations. The university dominates the district physically and socially. The natural sciences campus backs up against an escarpment where the rock face is exposed, and geologists have been quietly noting for years that the stratigraphy there matches the published descriptions of the geological formation the Meridian Line boring was approaching on the day of the Pocket Fire.

The academic community's relationship with the cover-up is complicated. The university receives city funding. Several senior administrators sit on municipal boards. The institutional pressure is not overt, but researchers who have submitted grant applications mentioning the Pocket Fire geology have found the applications quietly delayed, then denied, then not mentioned again. The message has been received.

What has happened instead is informal. A mycology postdoc studying fungal bioluminescence obtained samples from a tunnel-user contact and has been analyzing them on her own time using equipment she is not authorized to use for non-departmental research. A structural engineering professor has been building a private dataset of ground-movement readings from sensors he installed around the old Ironbell Station perimeter, telling his department head they are calibration instruments. A retired biology chair meets monthly with the Lamplighters and has been doing so for six years.

The cameras in Tessmer Heights are the least dense of any district, partly because the university negotiated reduced coverage as a condition of a facilities agreement, and partly because the city does not particularly worry about academics. This has turned out to be an error.

Signature locations: The Veldrun Natural History Museum's geology wing, which contains a locked case of samples from the pre-Fire boring survey that the museum director does not know the provenance of. The Postdoc Flat on the third floor of the biology building where the mycology researcher works at night, windows dark except for the faint blue-green glow of her specimen trays. The Ridge Path, a public walking trail along the escarpment that passes within forty meters of a sealed tunnel vent shaft, which occasionally exhales a faint luminescent mist on cold mornings.

What the cameras mean here: Academics have more privacy than other districts by default. This has made Tessmer Heights a meeting place for people who need to have conversations the city would prefer not to happen.

The Margin

The Contested Quarter

The Margin occupies the low ground between the Colonnades and the waterfront, a district that exists because people needed somewhere to be and the city never got around to planning what that somewhere should look like. It is dense, horizontal, and layered in a way the other districts are not: buildings added onto other buildings, upper floors cantilevered out over narrow streets, market stalls occupying spaces that are technically transit easements. The architecture is not retro-futurist because nobody with a budget for retro-futurism chose to build here. What exists is adaptive, which is its own kind of intelligence.

The Margin is where a significant portion of Veldrun's migrant population lives, people who came to the city for work and discovered that the city's official hospitality had a narrow bandwidth. The facial recognition cameras here are calibrated, in effect if not in design, to flag people whose faces do not match registration records. This is not stated policy. It is an emergent outcome that the city has not moved to correct.

The tunnels beneath the Margin carry more daily traffic than any other section of the network. For many residents, the underground is not an alternative to the surface: it is the primary way they move. The vouching system here is community-based and fast, built on neighborhood trust networks that predate the Stewards' formal council. The Margin's tunnel culture is the warmest and most social in the network. There are underground gathering spaces below the Margin that the Stewards acknowledge but do not govern: a meeting hall, a medical clinic run by a retired physician who asks no identification, a schoolroom that operates three days a week.

The Margin is also where the broker selling unauthorized tunnel access has set up shop, which the Stewards find alarming precisely because the Margin's vouching networks are so embedded that an outsider offering bypass access is either extraordinarily well-connected or has inside information.

Signature locations: The Street of Flags, where residents have hung textiles from upper windows for decades until the street is permanently canopied and the cameras cannot see the ground level clearly. The Underground Clinic, two levels below a noodle shop, accessible through a door that looks like a utility closet and is lit entirely by Bloom growth that a Lamplighter has been cultivating for three years. The Margin Voice, a hand-printed newsletter that has been publishing twice a week for eleven years, distributed by hand, never digitized, never scannable.

What the cameras mean here: The cameras in the Margin are the sharpest operational threat in residents' daily lives. The Street of Flags is a direct community response. The tunnels are not a convenience here. They are how people stay free.

Saltgate

The Industrial Port

Saltgate is the oldest part of Veldrun and it smells like it: brine, diesel, the cold metallic scent of refrigerated cargo. The port facilities run along the southern waterfront, a working industrial landscape of cranes, container yards, cold storage warehouses, and processing plants that handle the fish and cargo that still constitute a meaningful portion of the city's economy. The space-race aesthetic arrived here as functional infrastructure rather than civic statement: the crane housings are painted in the city's official turquoise, the warehouse facades carry the municipal logo in clean sans-serif, and that is the extent of the idealism.

Saltgate's tunnel access points are the least ceremonial in the network. Most are inside warehouses where shift workers have known about them for twenty years and the warehouse owners have chosen not to know. Several access points sit in the sub-basements of cold storage facilities, which means the tunnels near Saltgate are notably colder than the rest of the network, and the Bloom grows differently there: slower-pulsing, deeper blue, less reactive to movement. The Lamplighters find this section of the network the most otherworldly.

The port also means Saltgate has a transient population: sailors, seasonal workers, cargo handlers who are in the city for weeks and then gone. This creates both opportunity and risk for the tunnel network. Transient users are harder to vouch for and harder to hold accountable. The Line Warden assigned to the Saltgate section is the most experienced in the council, a former dockworker in her late sixties who has been doing this for fifteen years and who has a particular talent for reading people quickly.

Saltgate's cameras cover the port perimeter and main cargo roads but are thinner inside the warehouse districts, partly because the camera infrastructure is harder to maintain in the salt air. The port authority and the city's surveillance office have been arguing about maintenance funding for three years. This argument has, inadvertently, created the most camera-sparse district in Veldrun.

Signature locations: Warehouse 9-C, a cold storage facility whose sub-basement contains the largest single tunnel access point in the network, wide enough for the handcarts to pass through without disassembly. The Saltgate Fish Market, open at 4am, where the Line Warden holds informal office hours over coffee. The Reef Wall, a long breakwater at the southern edge of the port where the city's corrosion engineers have been finding inexplicable organic mineral deposits on the underwater pilings, deposits that match the secretion profile of the Architects.

What the cameras mean here: Saltgate's camera gaps are known to everyone who matters. The port's transience makes it both the network's most porous entry point and its most unpredictable one. Something will eventually come in through Saltgate that the Stewards were not ready for.

Want to develop specific named characters in any of these districts next, or start building out one of the story hooks with this geography in place?

lets build out the "what lives below" next

Before I go deeper on the ecology, I want to make sure it's calibrated right.

These three answers set the register for the entire ecology. Take your time with them.

Q: How scientifically grounded do you want the biology to feel? This sets the tone for how characters talk about and understand what they find.
A: Hard science — everything has a plausible real-world biological mechanism, even if strange

Q: The compound from the geological cavity is the origin of all the strangeness. What do you want its nature to ultimately be?
A: A natural substance — ancient, pre-human, with no agenda

Q: The deep water in the flooded sub-basement is the biggest unknown. How strange do you want what lives there to be?
A: Strange but biological — something that evolved in isolation, like a cave ecosystem taken further

Excellent constraints. Hard science, ancient natural origin, biological deep water. This is going to feel like a Michael Crichton chapter in the best possible way.

What Lives Below: The Tunnel Ecology of Veldrun

The Compound: Velite

The geological cavity the Meridian Line boring breached in 1948 contained a substance the city's classified surveys designated Compound V. Among the Stewards and the Lamplighters it has acquired a name: **velite**, after the old Latin word for a skirmisher, a soldier who moves ahead of the main force. The name came from a Tessmer Heights classicist who spent time below and thought the compound's behavior fit: it goes first, it changes the ground for everything that follows.

Velite is a naturally occurring organometallic fluid, almost certainly a product of anaerobic microbial metabolism operating over geological timescales in a sealed, mineral-rich cavity with no oxygen and no light. Its closest real-world analogues are the exotic sulfur compounds found in deep hydrothermal vent systems, but velite formed in a continental shelf cavity rather than an oceanic one, under different pressure, different temperature, different mineral input. The result is chemically unlike anything in the published literature.

What velite does, in practical terms, is act as an extraordinarily efficient biological catalyst. It does not create life. It accelerates and redirects existing biological processes in ways that would normally require millions of years of evolutionary pressure. Organisms exposed to velite do not mutate randomly. They optimize, rapidly and efficiently, for the specific conditions velite creates: low light, high humidity, stable temperature, rich mineral substrate. The ecology that has grown in the tunnels over twenty-seven years is not unnatural. It is natural processes running on a dramatically compressed timeline.

The Pocket Fire happened because velite, when exposed to open air and the heat of boring equipment, produces a brief and violent exothermic reaction before stabilizing. The gas that killed the workers was not toxic in the traditional sense. It was superheated velite vapor displacing oxygen. The city's classified surveys showed this clearly. The city sealed the network because they did not know how much velite remained in the surrounding geology, and because explaining what velite was would have required explaining what it does, and explaining what it does to biology would have raised questions about the workers who survived the initial incident and later died of causes their families were told were unrelated.

Velite itself, in its stabilized form, is not acutely dangerous to humans. Long-term exposure is another question, and the answer to that question is still being written by the bodies of people who have spent years underground.

The Bloom

The dominant feature of the tunnel ecology and the one most tunnel-users encounter first is the fungal network the Lamplighters call the Bloom. It covers approximately sixty percent of the tunnel wall and ceiling surface across the active network and is, by any biological standard, one of the most sophisticated fungal organisms ever to exist without anyone in a university laboratory knowing about it.

The Bloom is not a single species. It is a consortium: at least seven distinct fungal taxa operating as an integrated superorganism, connected by hyphal networks so dense that a cubic centimeter of wall substrate contains more fungal connections than a human brain contains synapses. The bioluminescence is produced by a luciferin-luciferase reaction similar to the one found in foxfire fungi, but velite-optimized to produce light across a broader spectrum, including a faint component in the near-infrared that human eyes cannot see but that other tunnel organisms have evolved to use.

The pulse that the Lamplighters read is real and informative. The Bloom's light output modulates in response to environmental conditions through a mechanism that functions like a distributed nervous system: chemical signals propagate through the hyphal network and translate into coordinated bioluminescent changes across large surface areas. Faster pulses correlate with elevated CO_2 levels. A slow deep throb typically indicates high humidity and stable conditions. A specific arrhythmic flickering pattern, which experienced Lamplighters call the stutter, precedes structural stress events by anywhere from twenty minutes to several hours. Nobody has worked out the exact mechanism. The retired biology chair from Tessmer Heights has a working hypothesis involving piezoelectric stress signals in the mineral substrate propagating through the hyphal network, and she thinks she is right but cannot publish without revealing her data source.

The Bloom retreats from bright artificial light because its luciferin production is metabolically expensive and the organism has evolved to suppress it when external light renders it redundant. The retreat is not instantaneous: the hyphal network has to redistribute metabolic resources, which takes time. The result is that a section of tunnel illuminated with a powerful torch will show reduced Bloom activity for two to four hours afterward. Lamplighters who find a section going dark first check for recent artificial light use before assuming structural problems. Sometimes they are wrong about which it is.

The Bloom extends fine surface hyphae into the concrete and tile of the tunnel walls, extracting mineral nutrients and, critically, trace velite that has leached into the substrate from the surrounding geology over decades. This velite uptake is what makes the Bloom's bioluminescence so efficient and its distributed signaling so fast. It is also what makes the Bloom's spores mildly bioactive: humans who spend significant time in areas of heavy Bloom growth inhale spores regularly, and those spores carry trace velite. The long-term effects of this are the compound persistence phenomenon the Stewards have been quietly tracking.

The Tunnel Mice

What the Stewards call tunnel mice are technically a distinct subspecies of the common house mouse, separated from their surface relatives by approximately eighteen to twenty generations of velite-accelerated adaptation. They are not mutants in any alarming sense. They are a cave-adapted population that got there very fast.

They are fully eyeless, the orbital structures having been reabsorbed over generations in a process velite appears to accelerate by upregulating the same genetic pathways that produce eye regression in natural cave fish populations, just much faster. The skin is translucent, showing the underlying musculature and, in well-fed individuals, a faint bluish tinge from the bioluminescent bacteria that colonize their digestive tracts. These bacteria are a velite-optimized strain of the same genus found in many marine bioluminescent organisms, and they appear to have been vectored into the mouse population through contaminated food sources early in the tunnel closure period.

The gut bacteria provide the mice with a secondary navigational sense. The bioluminescence is dim and primarily in wavelengths humans can barely detect, but other tunnel organisms, including the Bloom, respond to it. The mice and the Bloom appear to have developed a mutualistic relationship: the mice deposit spores as they move through the network, extending the Bloom's reach into areas it could not colonize unaided, and the Bloom's near-infrared light output gives the mice environmental information they use for navigation. Neither organism planned this. It is simply what twenty-seven years of velite-accelerated coevolution produces.

They are not aggressive, do not carry surface-world pathogens in any form recognizable to surface medicine, and are genuinely indifferent to human presence in a way that reads as calm. The Stewards' superstition about them as good omens has a practical basis: a tunnel section with healthy, active tunnel mice is a tunnel section with good air quality, stable

Bloom growth, and no recent structural disturbance. They are, functionally, a living environmental monitoring system.

The Architects

The Architects are the tunnel ecology's most consequential and least understood members, and the scientific case for what they are is fascinating enough that the Tessmer Heights researchers who know of their existence have difficulty thinking about much else.

They appear to be isopods: crustaceans in the order Isopoda, which includes the common pill bug and a wide range of marine and terrestrial relatives. The deep cave systems of the world contain many isopod species, most of them small, pale, and eyeless. The Architects are not small. The largest observed individuals are approximately eighty centimeters in length, a size that would be extraordinary for any isopod and is not explainable by normal cave gigantism alone. Velite-driven metabolic optimization is the only current hypothesis.

They are eyeless and slow-moving, with heavily mineralized exoskeletons that have taken on a bluish-gray color from velite compound absorption. They feed primarily on Bloom biomass and on the mineral-rich seepage water that collects in low sections of the tunnel floor. The mineral processing that happens in their digestive systems produces a calcium-silicate secretion they apply to tunnel walls, ceilings, and structural joints. This secretion sets hard and bonds well with concrete, and structural analysis of sections the Architects have worked shows measurably improved load distribution and crack resistance. They are, in the most literal sense, maintaining the tunnels.

Whether this is intentional in any meaningful sense is the question that makes the Tessmer Heights structural engineer lie awake at night. The current best hypothesis is that it is not intentional but is also not random: the Architects appear to preferentially apply their secretion to surfaces showing stress-related microcracking, which they may detect through vibration sensitivity in their legs and antennae. They are responding to structural information. They are not engineering. But the distinction feels increasingly fine the longer you watch them work.

The Architects' retreat that appears in the story hooks is biologically alarming for a specific reason: isopods do not typically aggregate or exhibit coordinated group behavior. If the Architects are moving together toward the deep tunnels, something is driving that movement, and the most likely candidates are either a change in the velite concentration gradient in the substrate, a change in the deep water chemistry, or a threat-response to something the Architects' vibration sensitivity is detecting that human instruments are not.

The Listening

The subsonic hum reported in the Scar Zones has a mundane candidate explanation and a less mundane one, and experienced tunnel-users tend to believe the less mundane one not because they are credulous but because they have heard both and know the difference.

The mundane explanation: the Scar Zone tunnels are closest to the original geological cavity, which was not fully collapsed by the Pocket Fire. Residual velite seepage through the fractured rock creates a slow-pressure cycling in the remaining cavity space that produces infrasound in the 14 to 18 Hz range. This is enough to create the sensation of unease, presence, and mild auditory hallucination in humans, which is a well-documented physiological response to infrasound at those frequencies. The geology is, in effect, haunting people.

The less mundane explanation, which does not contradict the first one: the Bloom in the Scar Zones is the oldest and densest in the network. Its hyphal connections there run deeper into the substrate, closer to the velite source, and its distributed signaling network in that section is correspondingly more complex. The retired biology chair has recorded the Bloom's chemical signal propagation in the Scar Zones and found patterns of a complexity that, in any neural tissue, would indicate something like response and modeling rather than simple environmental reaction. She has not published this. She has shared it with one person, the mycology postdoc, who read the data three times and then went very quiet.

What the Bloom is doing in the Scar Zones, if it is doing anything in a meaningful sense, is unknown. What the Stewards know from experience is that people who spend extended time in the Scar Zones come back different in subtle ways: more attuned to the tunnel environment, more sensitive to the pulse variations, occasionally reporting a sense of spatial awareness that extends beyond normal proprioception. None of this has been harmful. All of it has been noted.

Compound Persistence: The Human Variable

The velite exposure effects in long-term tunnel-users are real, measurable, and the Stewards' most closely held secret.

The mechanism works through the Bloom spores, which carry trace velite into the respiratory system during normal breathing in tunnel environments. Velite's catalytic properties act on existing biological tissue the same way they act on other organisms: they accelerate optimization for the tunnel environment. In humans this manifests gradually, over years of regular exposure, and only in specific physiological systems.

Low-light vision improvement is the most common and earliest effect. The rod photoreceptor density in the peripheral retina increases measurably in long-term tunnel-users. This is not blindness. It is the opposite: people who have spent five or more years regularly using the tunnels can navigate in light levels that would leave surface-adapted eyes functionally useless. They describe it not as seeing in the dark but as the dark becoming less total.

Infrasound sensitivity develops in a subset of long-term users, appearing to correlate with time spent in the Scar Zones specifically. Affected individuals describe an acquired ability to sense structural and environmental information below the normal threshold of hearing: not as sound but as a felt quality of space, a sense of whether a section is under stress before any visible sign appears. Several of the most experienced Line Wardens have this sensitivity and use it routinely in their assessments.

Bioluminescent skin response is the rarest and most striking effect and occurs only in individuals with the heaviest cumulative exposure. Under UV light, the skin of affected individuals shows a faint blue-green shimmer, concentrated in areas of high capillary density: the inner wrists, the throat, the temples. In normal light it is invisible. The physiological mechanism involves velite-modified mitochondria in skin cells that have taken up a luciferin analog from years of spore exposure. It is not dangerous. It is, if you know what you are looking at, a record of how long someone has lived below.

The Stewards track these effects carefully and voluntarily. Nobody is forced to report. Most do, because the Stewards made a specific decision early in the council's history: they would not become the city. They would not hide what they knew about what the tunnels did to people. They would share it, manage it, and let individuals make informed choices. This has not stopped people from using the tunnels. It has made people trust the Stewards.

What nobody knows yet, including the retired biology chair and the mycology postdoc who between them have the most complete picture of the ecology, is whether the effects plateau or continue to progress with extended exposure. The oldest Stewards have been using the tunnels for twenty-five years. They are watching themselves for the answer.

The Deep Water

The flooded sub-basement of the Meridian Line's central hub went underwater within the first year of the network closure, fed by a groundwater intrusion that the sealed transit authority never pumped out. The water is now approximately eleven meters deep at the lowest point, cold, lightless to human eyes, and essentially undisturbed for twenty-seven years.

The Stewards' prohibition on the deep water is not superstition. It is the result of the one documented entry, which occurred fourteen years ago when two young Stewards went in against explicit orders, with waterproof torches, and came back having seen enough that both of them requested the Keeper-Generals institute a formal ban rather than a social one. Neither has described in detail what they saw. Both are still Stewards. One is now a Keeper-General.

What can be inferred from biological first principles: the deep water is a velite-saturated environment that has been sealed, stable, and rich in mineral substrate for nearly three decades. Any organism that colonized it early in the closure period has been subject to continuous velite-accelerated adaptation in total darkness, under pressure, with no surface input. The isopod lineage that produced the Architects almost certainly has a deep-water branch. Cave-adapted fish, if any were present in the groundwater system, would have optimized rapidly. Microbial mats in velite-rich water would have developed chemical communication systems of a complexity that makes the Bloom's Scar Zone behavior look simple.

The thing the two young Stewards saw in their torchlight was large, slow, and not alarmed by them. It moved away from the light rather than toward it, which is why they came back. They described its movement as deliberate, which is a word that carries more weight than they probably intended.

The mineral deposits the corrosion engineers found on the Saltgate pier pilings are the first evidence that whatever lives in the deep water is not entirely contained there. The deposits match Architect secretion chemistry but show adaptations consistent with an aquatic environment. Something is moving through the groundwater system beneath the city, working on infrastructure it cannot see, for reasons nobody has yet determined.

It is almost certainly not aware of the city above it in any meaningful sense. Almost certainly.

Ready to move to characters next, or do you want to develop the scientific discovery arc: who figures out what, in what order, and what they do with the knowledge?

can you create a representative image/illustration for each type of creature that lives below.

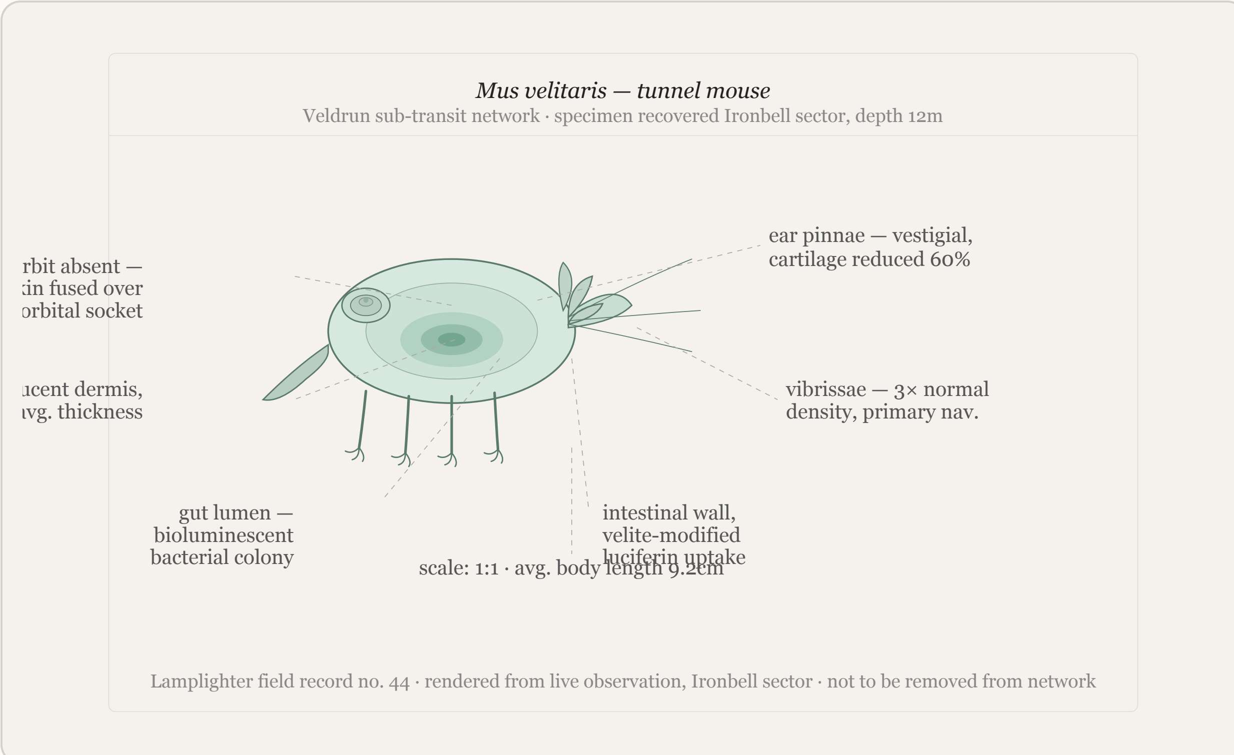
I can't search for or generate images of these creatures directly, but I can do something that might actually serve your worldbuilding better: hand-illustrated field-guide style SVG drawings of each creature, styled like scientific specimen plates from a 1960s natural history journal. That fits Veldrun's aesthetic perfectly and gives you something unique to the world.

Let me draw them one at a time with notes.

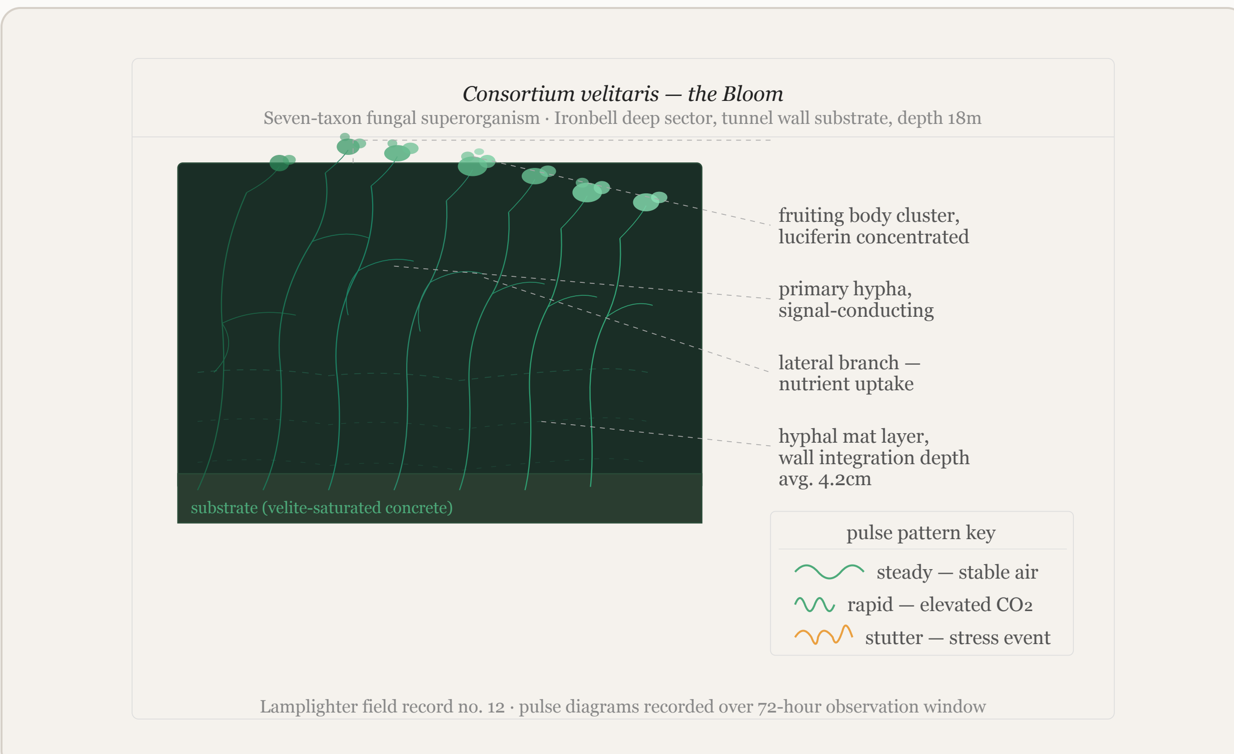
The Tunnel Mouse

The Bloom

The Architects



tunnel mouse specimen



bloom specimen

OK, not sure that was worth it. Let's instead go deeper on the stewards

Fair call. The illustrations were a nice detour but the Stewards are where the real story lives. Let me ask a few sharp questions before building them out.

These three answers will tell me the council's fault lines, whose eyes we see through, and what secret is quietly rotting the organization from inside.

Q: The Keeper-General council has seven members. What's the internal dynamic that creates the most interesting friction?
A: People united by the Fire's legacy vs. people who just need the network to survive

Q: Who is the protagonist-adjacent Steward — the one a story would most naturally follow?
A: A Lamplighter who has figured out more about the Bloom than anyone should know

Q: What is the Stewards' greatest unresolved internal wound — the thing they haven't dealt with that will eventually force a reckoning?
A: They've known about the broker selling access for longer than they've admitted and didn't act fast enough

Perfect. A scientist-by-accident protagonist, a council split between memory and pragmatism, and a cover-up inside the organization that's supposed to prevent cover-ups. Let's build them.

The Stewards of Veldrun

The Organization's Soul

The Stewards were not designed. They accreted. In the first years after the network closure, the people who kept returning to the tunnels despite the sealing were the ones with the most reason to: families of the dead who couldn't accept the official story, transit workers who had lost their livelihoods, Margin residents for whom the tunnels were already a lifeline. They started sharing information about safe entry points. Then they started coordinating maintenance. Then, slowly, they started making rules together.

What holds the Stewards together is not ideology but a shared experience of being failed by official things. The Pocket Fire families know what a government cover-up looks like from the inside. The Margin residents know what it means to be watched and still not protected. The former transit workers know what it is to have institutional knowledge that the institution has discarded. None of these groups would have found each other above ground. Below, they are the same thing: people who decided to be responsible for something the city abandoned.

The organization's deepest value, stated plainly at every new Keeper-General induction, is this: we do not become the city. We do not hide what we know. We do not make decisions for people without telling them what we know. The broker situation has been quietly violating this value for fourteen months. Most of the council knows it. Nobody has said it out loud yet.

The Council Fault Line: Legacy vs. Survival

The seven Keeper-Generals divide, roughly and without formal acknowledgment, into two orientations that shape every significant decision the council makes.

The Legacy faction, three of the seven, are people for whom the tunnels are inseparable from the Pocket Fire. They came to the network through grief or through the families of the dead, and they carry the network's history as a moral obligation. For them, the rules are not pragmatic guidelines: they are the specific shape of the promise the Stewards made to the people the city abandoned. Compromising the rules, even tactically, even temporarily, is a betrayal of the dead. They are not wrong. They are also sometimes unable to move.

The Survival faction, three others, are people for whom the tunnels are a present-tense necessity. They came to the network because they needed it, not because of what happened twenty-seven years ago. They have family members who depend on the underground clinic. They have neighbors who cannot move above ground without triggering the recognition grid. For them, abstract principle that puts living people at risk is a luxury. They are not wrong either. They are sometimes willing to cut corners that should not be cut.

The seventh Keeper-General, Dessa Vorne, holds the balance. She is the only council member trusted equally by both factions, which means she is also the one most exhausted by the position, most aware of what the broker situation has cost the organization's integrity, and most likely to be the person who finally forces the reckoning.

The Seven Keeper-Generals

Dessa Vorne, 58. The de facto chair, though the Stewards have no formal chair. She was twelve years old when her father died in the Pocket Fire. She spent her twenties organizing the families who accepted the settlement and the ones who refused it, trying to hold both groups together. She came to the tunnel network in her thirties, already an experienced organizer, and the Stewards absorbed her capabilities within a year. She has the Legacy faction's memory and the Survival faction's practicality, which makes her indispensable and occasionally makes her complicit in things she knows are wrong. She has known about the broker for fourteen months. She told herself she was gathering information before acting. She has been lying to herself and she knows it. She is waiting for someone to force her hand because she cannot seem to force it herself.

Orrin Paz, 71. The oldest Keeper-General and the only one who was a transit worker on the day of the Pocket Fire, though not in the affected section. He was twenty-two years old, three months into his first posting, working a surface electrical junction when the alarm came through. He has worked in the tunnels in some capacity for every year since. He is the institutional memory: he knows where every access point is, which sections were reinforced in which decade, where the original boring surveys said the geology was unstable. He is Legacy in orientation but not rigidly so. His position is simpler than ideology: the tunnels exist, they need to be maintained, and the people who use them deserve safety. Everything else is secondary. He is deeply uncomfortable about the broker and has said so to Dessa twice. He accepted her "we're still gathering information" explanation both times because he wanted to believe it and because he is old enough to know that he is not always right.

Yael Construct, 44. The Legacy faction's most intellectually forceful voice and its most difficult personality. She is the granddaughter of one of the Pocket Fire dead and grew up with the non-disclosure agreement as a kind of family mythology: the document her grandmother signed, the money that came with it, the silence that followed. She became a Keeper-General at thirty-one and has held the position since on the strength of her organizational intelligence and the friction she creates by being reliably, usefully uncompromising. She does not trust the Survival faction members and does not hide it. She has been loudest about the broker situation and has suspected for months that the council's inaction is not information-gathering but reluctance. She is building a case. When she presents it, it will be airtight and it will be devastating and she will have thought carefully about what she wants to happen afterward, which is more than most people in her position would do.

Sable Morrow, 39. Survival faction. She grew up in the Margin and has been using the tunnels since she was fifteen. Her mother used the underground clinic for three years before dying of an illness the surface medical system would have caught earlier if her mother had been able to afford an ID-verified appointment. Sable came to the Stewards not through the Fire but through that loss and through the specific fury of watching bureaucratic systems protect themselves rather than people. She is practical, fast-thinking, and genuinely good at the organizational work of keeping the network running. She also has a tendency, when the choice is between protecting the institution and protecting a specific person in front of her, to choose the person. This has occasionally been right. It is the instinct that allowed the broker situation to go on too long: someone argued that the broker was serving people the vouching system was failing to reach, and Sable found that argument harder to dismiss than she should have.

Tem Vaari, 52. Survival faction. A former dockworker from Saltgate who came to the tunnels when the port's facial recognition system flagged him incorrectly as a person of interest in a cargo theft investigation. The flag was cleared after four months. The surveillance record was not expunged. He spent those four months living primarily underground and emerged with a permanent, bone-deep understanding of what the tunnels mean to people with no other options. He is methodical, quiet, and the best logistical mind on the council. He manages the handcart schedule, the maintenance rotation, and the supply network for the underground clinic with a precision that the other Keeper-Generals rely on without fully appreciating. He has no strong feelings about the Fire's legacy as an abstraction. He has very strong feelings about keeping the network operational. He voted, informally, to allow the council more time on the broker situation because disruption to the current access patterns would create logistical chaos he was not prepared to manage. He regrets this.

Isolde Crane, 61. Legacy faction. She is the one who lost two children in the tunnels, which is not what it sounds like: both of them are alive, adults, living above ground, and they stopped speaking to her fifteen years ago because she chose the Stewards over their father when the marriage ended and she has never pretended otherwise. She is austere, exacting, and the council member most likely to call a vote when Dessa is delaying. She knows about Dessa's fourteen months of inaction on the broker and has not called a vote yet, which is the closest thing Isolde does to loyalty. She is waiting for Dessa to act voluntarily. She will not wait much longer.

Brin Okafor, 35. The youngest Keeper-General, Survival faction, elevated to the council two years ago when his predecessor retired. He is a second-generation tunnel-user, born in the Margin to parents who used the network before he could walk. He has no personal memory of the world before the tunnels existed as a community resource. This gives him a different relationship to the institution than anyone else on the council: for him it is not something that was built in response to a catastrophe. It simply is. He is genuinely puzzled by the weight the Legacy members carry, not dismissively but in the way a person is puzzled by a grief they didn't share. He is also the broker situation's most uncomfortable complication: he was the first Keeper-General to hear a specific rumor about who the broker might be, six weeks before Dessa's fourteen-month clock started, and he passed it to Dessa and considered his responsibility discharged. He was twenty-two years old at the time, newly appointed, and he was wrong about what his responsibility required. He has not told anyone he was first.

The Protagonist: Wren Adisa, Lamplighter

Wren is thirty-one years old, grew up in Tessmer Heights in a household adjacent to the university without ever belonging to it, and came to the tunnels at twenty-four through a Margin neighbor who needed someone to carry equipment and trusted Wren to keep quiet. She became a Lamplighter because the Bloom interested her in a way that nothing in her surface life had, and she became the Lamplighters' most technically capable member because she had the specific combination of patience, observational precision, and willingness to sit alone in the dark for hours that the work requires.

She does not have a science degree. She has something more useful: twelve years of direct Bloom observation, a naturalist's notebook practice she started in her first month underground, and an instinct for pattern recognition that has no formal name. She can read a pulse sequence the way a musician reads notation. She knows which corridor sections are healthy, which are stressed, which are doing something she has no framework for yet.

The thing she has figured out, and has not told anyone completely, is this: the Bloom in the Scar Zone sectors is not just responding to environmental conditions. It is modeling them. The pulse patterns she has recorded over the past three years show predictive behavior: the Bloom's signal changes precede structural stress events by a measurable interval, precede changes in tunnel mouse behavior by a measurable interval, and in two documented cases she has told no one about, preceded human events she cannot explain. A section of tunnel went into the stutter pattern four hours before a Steward maintenance team arrived to find a partial ceiling collapse. She logged it as coincidence. The second time it happened she stopped calling it coincidence and started calling it something she didn't have a word for.

She is not afraid of what she is learning. She is afraid of what the council will do with it if she tells them, and she is afraid of what the city will do with it if it gets further. She has been sitting on the most significant biological discovery in the tunnel's history for seven months, sharing pieces of it with the Tessmer Heights retired biology chair and nobody else, because she has not yet worked out how to give people information without giving them power over it.

Her compound persistence markers are the most advanced of any active Lamplighter. Her night vision is effectively complete at low light levels. She has the infrasound sensitivity. Under UV, her inner wrists show the bioluminescent response clearly enough that she wears long sleeves above ground in all weather. She has told no one except the retired biology chair, who is tracking it with a combination of scientific excitement and genuine concern that Wren finds more comforting than alarming.

What Wren wants, underneath everything, is for the tunnels to survive what is coming. She does not know yet what is coming. She suspects it is several things at once.

The Line Wardens: Three Portraits

Maret Solís, 67, Saltgate sector. The most experienced Line Warden in the network, the former dockworker referenced in the district profiles. She has the infrasound sensitivity strongly developed, uses it routinely, and describes it to new tunnel-users as "the tunnel talking." She is the Stewards' best reader of structural risk and the person

Dessa calls first when something goes wrong in the southern network. She is also the Warden who first identified the Saltgate pier deposits as matching Architect secretion chemistry and brought the information to Orrin Paz, who brought it to Dessa, who has been sitting on it for three months alongside everything else.

Callo Bright, 28, Margin sector. Young, fast, and the most socially embedded Warden in the network. He knows every family in the Margin who uses the tunnels, every access point, every informal gathering space below the district. He is the first person to hear rumors and the last person to repeat them without verification. He has heard two separate accounts of the broker's operation from people who used the service and regretted it. He has passed both accounts to Dessa. He is starting to wonder why nothing has happened.

Pell Okafor, 55, Ironbell sector. Brin's parent, which creates a structural awkwardness on the council that everyone politely ignores. Pell was a transit worker's spouse, not a worker themselves, and came to the Stewards through the family support networks that formed after the Fire. They are the Warden most trusted by the Fire families, the one who attends the anniversary gathering at the Tidal Steps every year, the one the oldest Ironbell residents will talk to about what they remember from before. They know things about the original disaster that have never made it into any Steward record, passed mouth to ear over thirty years by people who signed documents promising not to write things down.

The Wound: Fourteen Months

The broker first appeared in Steward awareness as a rumor in the Margin, eighteen months ago. Someone was offering tunnel access to people who couldn't get vouched through the standard network. The price was high but not extortionate: two weeks' wages for a guaranteed introduction, no questions about history or legal status.

Dessa heard the rumor and did what a careful leader does: she asked the Line Wardens to gather more information before the council acted. This was reasonable. Six months of information gathering produced a profile: the broker knew too much about tunnel geography to be purely external. Someone connected to the Stewards was involved.

That conclusion, when Dessa brought it to the full council fourteen months ago, should have triggered an immediate internal investigation. Instead it triggered a four-hour meeting that ended without a formal decision, because the question of who among the Stewards might be involved was too destabilizing to pursue quickly, and because Sable argued that the broker was serving people the system was failing, and because Brin said nothing about his earlier knowledge, and because Dessa told herself she needed more information.

What has happened in the fourteen months since: the broker has moved approximately ninety people through the network via unauthorized routes. At least twelve of those people have accessed sections they should not have been able to find. Three of those sections contain information about compound persistence cases the Stewards have been tracking. Someone now has that information who should not.

Yael Construct has reconstructed most of this from Line Warden reports and her own network of informal contacts. She will present it at the next full council meeting. She has not told Dessa she is going to do this. She is not going to warn her.

What the Stewards Look Like From Outside

To a first-time tunnel-user, the Stewards are a reassuring presence: competent, principled people who maintain something difficult with care and treat the people who depend on it with dignity. This is true. It is also incomplete.

The Stewards are an organization that has been carrying the weight of other people's secrets for twenty-seven years while trying not to become the kind of institution that keeps secrets. The broker situation is the first time they have clearly failed that standard. What they do next, and whether they can be honest about having failed it, will determine whether they are the organization they believe themselves to be or whether they are simply a smaller, kinder version of the city above.

Where next? We could build out specific characters in more depth, develop the broker's identity and operation, or start connecting the Stewards to one of the story hooks as a full plot structure.

Let's next build out Veldrun

Before I flesh out the city itself, a few targeted questions to make sure it feels lived-in rather than generic retro-futurist.

These three shape everything: the physical experience of moving through the city, Veldrun's psychology as a place, and who exactly is running the cover-up and why.

Q: Every great fictional city has a specific geography that shapes its politics and culture. What's Veldrun's dominant physical feature?
A: A ridge or escarpment — one side faces the sea, one faces inland, and the divide is cultural as much as physical

Q: What is Veldrun's relationship to the broader world? This shapes who comes here, why, and what the city thinks of itself.
A: An ideological showcase — built or rebuilt to demonstrate something, still performing that demonstration

Q: What does Veldrun's government actually look like? The surveillance grid exists, but who runs it and how do they justify it?
A: A single dominant party with genuine popular support that has held power long enough to forget the difference between the party and the city

Excellent. A showcase city on a divided ridge, run by a party that genuinely believes its own mythology. That's a rich and specific kind of political tragedy. Here is Veldrun, fully built out.

Veldrun: The City in Full

The Physical City

Veldrun sits on the Crestline Ridge, a geological formation running roughly northeast to southwest for eleven kilometers, rising to a maximum height of 140 meters above sea level at its central peak before descending on both sides. The ridge is not a gentle slope. On its western face it drops sharply toward the Velder Sea in a series of terraced cliffs and steep streets that required significant civil engineering to make habitable. On its eastern face the descent is longer and more gradual, opening into the Inland Plain, a flat agricultural and light-industrial territory that stretches to the horizon and feeds the city.

This geography has produced two Veldruns that share a name and a government and very little else in the way of daily experience.

The Seaward city, on the western face and the ridge crest, is Veldrun as it presents itself to the world. The Meridian sits at the top, its towers visible from the water twelve kilometers out. The Colonnades occupy the upper terraces, their elevated walkways engineered to follow the contour lines. Tessmer Heights occupies the northern end of the ridge crest, its university buildings arranged along the escarpment's edge where the geology exposed by the ridge face provides convenient outdoor laboratory conditions. Property on the Seaward side costs three times what it costs on the Inland side. The camera grid on the Seaward side is maintained to a higher technical standard. The streets are wider. The tile work in the transit corridors is intact.

The Inland city is where Veldrun actually functions. Ironbell occupies the lower Inland slopes at the ridge's southern end, close enough to the port that the foundry workers could historically walk to the docks in twenty minutes. Saltgate sits at the bottom of the Inland descent on the southern waterfront, connected to the port infrastructure by rail lines that predate the city's modernization and have never been replaced because they still work. The Margin fills the flat ground between Ironbell's lower streets and the Saltgate docks, a district that grew because people needed to be somewhere near work and the Seaward city had already allocated its space.

The ridge itself, the literal top, is occupied by the Civic Spine: a four-kilometer pedestrian boulevard running the length of the crest, lined with the architectural statements that define Veldrun's public face. The Municipal Tower. The Transit Authority headquarters. The Hall of Progress, a museum of civic achievement that opened in 1961 and has been continuously updated ever since to reflect the city's ongoing achievements, its gallery of the future revised every few years as the previous future becomes the present and requires replacement. The Civic Spine is where visiting dignitaries are taken. It is where school groups come on field trips. It is where the party holds its annual Foundation Day celebration, which fills the boulevard with citizens who attend partly from genuine civic pride and partly because the cameras record attendance and the recording is not explicitly a requirement but everyone understands what it means.

The tunnel network runs beneath all of it. The Meridian Line's original route followed the ridge crest before branching into the Inland districts. The sealed stations beneath the Civic Spine are among the most ornate in the network: mosaic platforms, vaulted ceilings, original signage in the city's official typeface. The Stewards have kept these stations in the best condition of any section of the network, partly because the architecture deserves it and partly because the irony of maintaining the city's showcase infrastructure from below, invisibly, feels like something the Pocket Fire dead would appreciate.

The Ideological City

Veldrun was not purpose-built as a showcase. It became one, which is a different and more interesting thing.

The city's modern identity was forged in the years immediately following the Second Consolidation War, a regional conflict that ended in 1951 with Veldrun on the winning side and with a peace settlement that gave the city significant territorial and economic advantages over its neighbors. The party that had led the city through the war, the Veldrun Progressive Compact, emerged with genuine popular mandate and a specific idea about what to do with it: build a city that demonstrated what responsible, modern, technocratic civic governance could produce.

The Compact's founding proposition, still printed on the inside cover of every new citizen's identity document, reads: *A city that works for everyone works because everyone can see* *it working*. This is the philosophical root of the camera grid. Transparency, in the Compact's original formulation, was a mutual obligation: the city would be transparent about its operations and citizens would be transparent about theirs. The surveillance architecture was presented not as monitoring but as participation in a shared civic visibility. Many people found this genuinely persuasive. Some still do.

What the Compact built in the 1950s and 1960s was, by measurable standards, impressive. The Civic Spine. The public transit network, the one that became the Meridian Line. Universal primary healthcare. A housing program that eliminated the worst of the pre-war slum conditions. Veldrun in 1965 was a city that functioned better than most of its regional peers and knew it and was not modest about saying so. Delegations came from other cities to study the Compact's methods. Architects came to photograph the buildings. The party received this attention with the calm satisfaction of people who had expected to be right and been proven right.

The Pocket Fire happened in 1971. The cover-up began within hours. The gap between what the city was and what the city performed being has been widening quietly ever since.

The Government

The Veldrun Progressive Compact has governed the city without interruption for seventy-four years. It has done this through genuine electoral success, which is the detail that makes the political situation more interesting than a simple authoritarian story.

The Compact wins elections because it has, for most of its tenure, actually governed competently. The healthcare system works. The schools are good. The Civic Housing Authority has maintained housing quality in ways comparable cities have not. The camera network has, by the city's own statistics, produced measurably lower rates of certain categories of street crime. None of this is fabricated. The party's popular support is real.

What seventy-four years of uninterrupted power produces is not corruption in the obvious sense. It produces something subtler: an organization that has ceased to be able to distinguish between its own institutional interests and the public good. When the Pocket Fire happened and the party leadership decided to classify the geological surveys, they did not think of themselves as covering up a disaster to protect themselves. They thought of themselves as protecting the city's stability, which was the same thing as protecting the public good, which was what the Compact existed to do. The reasoning was circular and they did not notice the circle because the circle had been invisible for twenty years by then.

The current leadership structure has three tiers that matter for story purposes.

The Executive Directorate is the party's seven-member governing council, which maps to the city's official cabinet structure so completely that the distinction between party body and government body has become purely ceremonial. The Director-General is Petra Solm, 63, the first woman to hold the position, elected to it twelve years ago on a platform of institutional modernization that produced several genuine reforms and left the surveillance architecture and the classified geological archives entirely untouched. She is not a villain. She is a person who inherited a system that works and has chosen not to look at the parts that don't.

The Bureau of Civic Continuity is the administrative body that technically manages the camera network and the city's identity registration system. In practice it operates with minimal oversight, reporting to a single Directorate member on a quarterly basis. Its director, Hallam Vier, 51, is the most powerful unelected official in the city and the one with the most direct knowledge of the tunnel network's use by the city's own population. He has been receiving automated flagging reports about unusual movement patterns in the subsurface transit corridors for nine years. He has filed them in a folder labeled *anomalous infrastructure readings* and has never actioned them, because actioning them would require explaining why he hadn't actioned the previous eight years of reports.

The Transit Authority is technically an independent statutory body and in practice a Compact-aligned institution whose senior leadership is appointed by the Directorate. Its archive of classified geological surveys from the pre-Fire boring project sits in sub-basement three of its headquarters building, accessible to four people, three of whom have been told it concerns routine geological risk assessment and have no reason to look further. The fourth is Hallam Vier, who has read it.

What the City Performs and What It Is

Veldrun performs modernity. It performs civic health. It performs the proposition that a well-run city with good data about itself can make good decisions for everyone.

What it is, underneath the performance, is a city that made one catastrophic decision seventy-four years of good governance ago and has been architecturally committed to not revisiting it ever since. The classified surveys are not just evidence of the Pocket Fire cover-up. They contain the full velite analysis: what the compound is, what it does to biological systems, what it was doing to the tunnel environment when the network was sealed. The Compact's leadership in 1971 knew they were sealing an ecosystem in the making. They decided the alternative, explaining what velite was and acknowledging what it had done to the workers who survived the initial incident, was worse.

The city's camera network, its identity grid, its culture of managed visibility: all of it is infrastructure that made the cover-up sustainable. Not because it was designed for that purpose, but because a city that has normalized comprehensive surveillance of its citizens is a city that has also made it very difficult for citizens to organize around inconvenient truths. The Stewards exist in the gap this creates. They are the thing a surveilled city produces when some of its people refuse to be managed.

The City's Textures

What Veldrun sounds like. The Seaward districts have a specific acoustic character: the wind off the Velder Sea moves up the cliff face and through the Civic Spine at consistent pressure, producing a background note in the upper terraces that residents call the hum. It is distinct from the Listening in the tunnels and predates the tunnel ecology entirely, but newcomers who have been below sometimes pause on the Civic Spine and look uncertain, and the people who know about both sounds understand why. The Inland districts sound like industry: the foundry rhythms from Ironbell, the crane operations from Saltgate, the market noise from the Margin that starts before dawn and runs until the light fails.

What Veldrun smells like. On the ridge crest: salt air, the pine resin used in the Civic Spine's planter boxes, the particular metallic cleanliness of a city that maintains its surfaces. In Ironbell: coal smoke from the foundries, the mineral sharpness of the waterfront at low tide, bread from the union hall kitchen that runs a subsidized breakfast program six days a week. In the tunnels: the cool damp of deep earth, something faintly mineral and green that longtime users identify as velite-modified air, and in the Scar Zones a deeper note that has no surface analogue and that people describe differently depending on how long they have been going below.

What the cameras look like. Flush-mounted, matte gray housing, lens diameter approximately twelve millimeters. On lamp standards they sit at the junction between the pole and the lamp housing. On building facades they occupy purpose-built recesses in the curtain wall panels, barely visible at street level. On the Civic Spine they are integrated into the planter box brackets at two-meter intervals. The design is deliberately unobtrusive, which is itself a design statement: the city is not trying to intimidate with its surveillance. It is trying to normalize it. New residents often spend months in the city before they consciously register the cameras. Long-term residents have stopped registering them entirely, which is the intended endpoint.

What Foundation Day looks like. The Compact's annual celebration of the city's founding fills the Civic Spine from the Municipal Tower to the Hall of Progress. There are bands, civic speeches, a light display projected onto the cliff face that can be seen from the Inland districts and from ships twelve kilometers out. Children carry small flags in the city's colors, turquoise and white. The Director-General gives an address from the steps of the Municipal Tower that is carried on every broadcast screen in the city simultaneously. The attendance is large and largely genuine and the mood is a complicated mixture of real civic pride and the performance of civic pride that long-term residents have stopped being able to fully separate. In the tunnels below, the Foundation Day celebration produces the highest foot traffic of any day in the calendar year. The Bloom pulses at its most active. The tunnel mice, sensitive to the vibration of the crowds above, move to the deeper sections until the noise subsides.

The City's Specific Lies

Every showcase city has the things it doesn't show the visitors.

Veldrun doesn't show the eastern face of the ridge from the official tour routes. The Inland districts are accessible but not featured. The Hall of Progress contains no exhibit on the Meridian Line after 1969. The city's official history skips from the transit network's near-completion to its "temporary closure for safety assessment" without a date, without a cause, without the forty-one names.

The city's healthcare statistics, which are genuinely good, do not include the subset of cases that the Bureau of Civic Continuity has quietly routed to a separate tracking system: cases showing unusual physiological markers in patients who list certain Inland districts as their residence and certain occupations that correlate, to anyone looking carefully, with regular underground movement. Hallam Vier has access to this tracking system. He does not think of it as connected to the tunnels. He thinks of it as an anomalous public health cluster that has never risen to the threshold of requiring action. He has been thinking this for six years.

The one thing the city cannot hide and has stopped trying to is the Saltgate pier deposits. The port authority's corrosion engineers have been filing reports about the organic mineral formations on the underwater pilings for three years. The reports go to a Compact-aligned port official who forwards them to the Bureau of Civic Continuity, where they join Hallam Vier's anomalous infrastructure folder. The formations keep growing. They are now visible at low tide without equipment, a faint blue-gray crusting on the lower pier supports that tourists occasionally photograph and post on the city's civic notice boards with captions asking what the interesting mineral formation is. Nobody official has answered.

Maret Solís, the Saltgate Line Warden, walks past those piers every morning on her way to the fish market. She has been watching the formations grow for three years. She knows what they are. She is waiting to see who else figures it out first.

Ready to build a full plot structure around any of the story hooks, or would you like to develop the broader world outside Veldrun first?